



Receiving Confirmation

How experienced auditors make sense of AI-generated agreement with a judgment they had already formed

CENTRAL RESEARCH QUESTION

How do experienced auditors experience and make sense of receiving an AI-generated conclusion that confirms a judgment they had already formed?

1 · FOCUS AND RESEARCH PROBLEM

An auditor on a recurring engagement has always carried a prior conclusion forward. What is new is that an AI system now produces a conclusion of its own, and sometimes it agrees.

Research on AI and auditor judgment has focused primarily on the extent of reliance, which a survey can measure. What remains unexplored is the lived experience of receiving machine agreement with a judgment already formed.

Two things are being conflated: automation bias, a human tendency, and sycophancy, a property of the system. A magnitude-of-reliance measure cannot tell them apart.

Standards assume a competent human reviewer sits above the system. Firms and regulators are writing AI-use policy on that assumption now.

2 · RESEARCH PURPOSE

The purpose of this phenomenological study is to understand how experienced auditors experience and make sense of receiving an AI-generated conclusion that confirms a judgment they had already formed. The phenomenon under study is the experience of encountering machine-generated confirmation of a prior professional judgment.

3 · FRAMEWORK AND ASSUMPTIONS

SOCIAL CONSTRUCTIVIST · INDUCTIVE

ONTOLOGICAL

Multiple realities. Auditors' accounts of the experience are the data, not a proxy for one correct account.

EPISTEMOLOGICAL

First-person accounts, gathered in semi-structured audio-recorded interviews and read in the participant's own words before coding.

AXIOLOGICAL

A career in bank examination, regulatory reporting and internal audit, including building an AI review tool. Insider access and insider bias at once. Every occasion of feeling confirmed is entered in a confirmation hazard log.

METHODOLOGICAL

Phenomenology. A phenomenon shared across individuals at different firms, with no single site to enter.

4 · QUALITATIVE APPROACH

Phenomenology (Creswell & Poth, 2024). The question asks about experience and meaning making across individuals, which is what phenomenology is for.

- Case study needs a bounded site; this phenomenon crosses firms
- Grounded theory studies process; this study asks about experience
- Ethnography needs embedded access to a firm's review process

5 · DATA COLLECTION

ELIGIBILITY IS THE PHENOMENON

A participant must have received AI-generated output that confirmed a judgment they had already formed independently. General experience of AI-supported audit work does not qualify.

- Five or more years in audit or risk assurance, with recurring engagement responsibility
- Criterion sampling, 10 to 15. Saturation is a stopping rule, not a target
- No single site. Professional networks, association chapters, referral chains
- Semi-structured interviews, recorded and transcribed verbatim. Protocol piloted first, and pilot testers cannot become participants
- Encrypted storage, pseudonyms at transcription, named file plan

6 · DATA ANALYSIS

FIVE ACTIVITIES · NVIVO

- 1 Managing and organising. NVivo, named file plan, secure storage.
- 2 Reading and memoing. A dated reflexive journal, kept as evidence.
- 3 Describing and classifying. Horizontalisation, meaning units, clusters.
- 4 Developing interpretations. Textural and structural, then a composite.
- 5 Representing. A thematic map and a composite narrative.

7 · ETHICAL CONSIDERATIONS

- Written informed consent before recording begins
- IRB determination confirmed before any contact, not assumed
- Pseudonyms at transcription. No client, engagement or firm-identifying detail
- Withdrawal at any point, data destroyed on request
- Member checking of the composite description offered to every participant
- No confidential data to any public AI platform. AI use disclosed per FIU policy

8 · EXPECTED CONTRIBUTION

TO PRACTICE

Firms and regulators are writing AI-use policy on the assumption that human review is a working control. This describes what that review is actually like from inside it.

TO ACADEMIA

It separates automation bias from sycophancy, which measures of how much someone relied on a machine cannot distinguish.

9 · POTENTIAL LIMITATIONS

- Retrospective self-report. Participants describe an experience after the fact
- Insider researcher. Managed by the confirmation hazard log, not eliminated
- Context-dependent. Not intended to generalise
- One national standards environment, small purposive sample

TIMELINE

M1

IRB determination, protocol pilot

M2

Recruitment and consent

M3 to M5

Interviews, transcription, memoing

M5 to M7

Coding, clustering, composite

M8

Member checking and write-up

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Full list in the paper

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